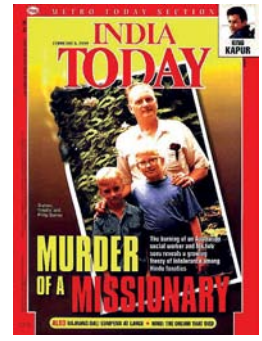
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Punjab is well known for its food, music, dance, dynamic people, the Green Revolution and, above all, the heart of Sikhism. Of late, though, another phenomenon has been causing some ferment in religious circles. It is the rise of Pentecostalism. The Charismatic movement that has become the fastest-growing branch of Christianity the world over is surging through Punjab's towns and villages in such a tidal wave that everyone else is sitting up and taking notice.

A handful of big pastors are the stars of this new groundswell. 'Apostle' Ankur Yoseph Narula is the biggest among them. Born to a Hindu Khatri family engaged in floor tiles and marble trading in Jalandhar, he converted to Christianity in 2008 and started his ministry with three members. Today, his Church of Signs and Wonders claims about 300,000 members worldwide. Besides the main church, coming up on a sprawling 65 acres in Khambra village off Jalandhar, the 'Ankur Narula Ministry' has branches in the US, Canada, Germany, one in Harrow, Greater London, and another in Birmingham, just inaugurated in October. There are a dozen-odd others like him, from all walks of life: doctors, engineers, advocates, cops, bureaucrats, businessmen and landlords, who either quit their professions to preach or do it on a Sunday basis. All with exuberant flocks, multiple centres in Punjab, massive YouTube following and, most importantly, claiming the power of miracles and wondrous acts of faith healing. Depending on how dramatic they are willing to be, their claims run the gamut: exorcising ghosts, curing everything from cancer to joint pain to infertility, helping with everything from deaddiction to jobs, matrimonial matches and visas.



February 8, 1999

At the other end of the scale are the village pastors. Here, you find assistant sub-inspectors, humble cloth merchants, small-time tailors and farm labourers, often running their Sunday sermons from a portion of their own house. They cater to devotees in more familiar ways, freely using Punjab's cultural markers—turban, langar, tappa, gidda—in their evangelism. As Managing Editor Sunil Menon, Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan and Group Photo Editor Bandeep Singh discovered, their satsangs could feel like group prayer sessions from any of the popular religions Punjab has known: Sikh, Hindu, Sufi. A majority of their followers come from the most exploited Dalit/ tribal communities: caste groups like the Mazhabi Sikh-Balmiki, Sansi, Rai Sikh, Bawaria, Bazigar, Barad, Bangala, Gadhile and Nat, who stay alienated from both Punjab's arc of prosperity and its elite-controlled religious institutions. These are the groups that used to flock to the deras—big and small—that offered a space outside the mainstream orthodoxy. But with some of the deras losing a bit of their sheen in the wake of scandals and controversies, Punjab's oppressed castes have found in Charismatic Christianity a new avenue to unshackle themselves from centuries of debasement and exploitation.

Their sheer profusion is causing disquiet in the mainstream institutions. There are no concrete figures, but one estimate pegs the number of pastors at an astounding 65,000, spread across Punjab's 23 districts, but with the highest concentration in the Majha and Doaba belts and the border areas of Ferozepur and Fazilka in Malwa. As for followers, Christians made up only 1.26 per cent of the state's total population in the 2011 census—at a headcount of 348,230. Square that against Narula's claimed flock of 300,000, the bulk of it on the ground in Punjab, and you see why it's raising an old bogey around conversions. Sikhism, eclectic and egalitarian in its core but over the past century marked by the domination of the powerful Jat Sikh community, is caught between tolerance and retaliation. As for the Hindu right wing, the theme of conversions feeds right into its narrative. Even the Catholic Church is watching bemused as the Pentecostals are drawing from their flock too.

Punjab is no stranger to Christianity. European missionaries landed here in mid-19th century, inaugurating a difficult conversation even before the end of the Anglo-Sikh wars in 1849. Ever since, mainstream denominations like the Catholic church as well as Protestant ones like the Presbyterians, Methodists and Anglicans have been part of its landscape. But the real surge came after 1873—over the next half century, as Punjab's most stigmatised caste groups chose to liberate themselves via baptism, the numbers grew to half a million. After Partition, India's share came to less than half of that. Things remained stable till the past decade saw the second wave, with an explosion of pastors and their eye-popping flocks. Caste is still the primary driver. That's why even senior activist Manjit Singh Bhoma, appointed by the Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee to counter "conversions" from Sikh families in Majha, admits, "If these Christian groups give their children access to education, books or health facilities, Sikh institutions like SGPC need to introspect what is wrong with that."

Punjab has stayed away from the kind of anti-conversion law that some other states have passed. Sikhism, by doctrine, is tolerant of all faiths and itself accepts those willing to be baptised. Still, the spectre of mass conversions to Christianity has all sides agitated. On September 5, at Anandpur Sahib, Akal Takht Jathedar Giani Harpreet Singh stirred the pot by asking the Sikh community to rethink its position over conversions. The Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee has even launched 'counter' initiatives like Ghar Ghar Andar Dharmsaal, where volunteers go door-to-door to spread the word of Sikhism.

The rhetoric is getting heated and radical Sikh groups are beginning to threaten the evangelists with retribution. On August 29, a group of Nihangs disrupted a Pentecostal programme in Daduana village, Amritsar, alleging "forced conversions". Two days later, masked intruders vandalised a Catholic church in Thakkarpura village, Tarn Taran, and burnt the priest's car. Christian activists took out mass protests on October 18, but overall, there is a pall of hushed fear. Punjab was the worst victim of India's bloody Partition and has also endured the dark phase of militancy. Both on the question of religion. India is a secular country, freedom of worship is enshrined in the Constitution. Perhaps the best way is to address the socio-economic conditions that drive people to change their faith. It behoves everyone to tread carefully and gently.

(Aroon Purie)